

Using Zoom Wisely

Ten thousand people have probably already warned you never to use Digital Zoom no matter how tempting it is, but we'd rather take no chances. Digital Zoom gives you grainy pictures, and the farther you stay away from it, the better.

However, there's plenty to worry about even when you're using optical zoom. The most popular is over-enthusiasm with the zoom control. You might remember the ad for a popular music channel—*"Joom in, joom in, joom in.....blaargh! Nononono pull out, pull out, pull out!"*—hilarious that it is, do you really want that in your videos? It's like you walked up to the subject, bonked your head on it and reeled back. If you want a close-up shot of something, try this: hit the pause button on your handycam to pause recording, zoom in and out as much as you want to get the right shot, and then hit the pause button again to resume recording. If this causes too much of a discontinuity in the video, consider using a cut-away shot (described in the next section) or just practise getting a better command of the zoom controls.

Alternatively, you could just eliminate using the zoom altogether. Wherever possible, just get closer to your subject and lean in or out to get the shot you want. You'll even get better sound from the subject this way. Of course, you'll need to keep your hand steady.

Steady, Steady

One of the most undesirable characteristics of home movies is the standard "camera shake" that mars so many shots. One of the best things you can do for jitter-free video is invest in a tripod.

If, however, the tripod gets too cumbersome (and it sometimes will), you could purchase a monopod (like a tripod, only with one leg)—it's less painful to handle than a tripod, gives you more freedom with camera angles, and yet lets you shoot smooth, steady video for all to enjoy.